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Independent Telecom & Infrastructure Advisory

WHITEPAPER · OCTOBER 2026

# THE LOST PROMISE OF 5G AND THE LAST CHANCE FOR 6G

*Why 5G's promised revenue never materialised, and what executive teams must do differently before committing to 6G*

**What's inside**

Seven sections on why 5G fell short of the new revenue promised to executive leadership teams, and what that means for 6G — covering the original vendor business case, what operators actually earned, nine root causes including Korea's speed rankings and the limits of the 3GPP process, the operators now making 5G SA pay, where and how 5G has succeeded, including in China, the state of the 6G debate, nine lessons for 6G, each with the questions to answer before committing — with a 6G roadmap exhibit and more than 40 sources.

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## Executive summary

The 5G business case sold to executive leadership teams was built on new enterprise revenue that never materialised. Around 2018, 5G was promised as the engine of industry digitalisation: operators would use it to change how factories, utilities, hospitals, transport and other sectors operate. Ericsson put the prize at US$204–619 billion by 2026, or 12–36% on top of operators' US$1.7 trillion of service revenue. 2026 has come and is now nearly gone, and GSMA reports that mobile revenue growth has barely kept pace with inflation through the 5G era.

The value that did land came from places the original story underplayed: fixed wireless access, cheaper capacity, and a handful of premium experience tiers. The headline vertical revenue pool — slicing, URLLC, private networks, edge — remains small, late and in many markets given away to defend share.

6G now has a timetable: first specifications in early 2029 and commercial systems around 2030. Operators have learned the cost lessons of 5G and are saying so loudly: standalone from day one, no forced hardware refresh, upgrades through software. They have learned the revenue lessons far less, and the greatest risk is commercial rather than technical: one large operator selling the 6G logo instead of its value can pull an entire market back into a race to the bottom.

> **The central lesson is simple: a new network capability does not create revenue on its own; solving a business need that a customer will pay for does.** Earlier generations sold capabilities because demand was already waiting; 5G's capabilities arrived ahead of demand. So operators must define the business need and establish what it is worth to the buyer — ideally with an anchor customer committed — before building, pricing and marketing the service. Build the network for efficiency and capacity; invest in new services only where the need is proven.

In this paper I set out what was promised, what happened, why, where and how it was successful, and the principles executive leadership teams should apply before committing to a 6G programme and taking it to the board for sanction:

1. Fund outcomes, not generations.
2. Make the network sellable from day one, not just available.
3. Sell business outcomes, not network capabilities.
4. Win through partners where demand is fragmented.
5. Build your own business case, and tie spending to revenue, not rollout.
6. Build the market before the network.
7. Count efficiency as a legitimate return, and say so out loud.
8. Decouple innovation from the standards clock.
9. Refuse the logo race, and plan for a rival who won't.

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## 1. What was promised

The CxO pitch for 5G rested on one idea: the network would stop selling gigabytes and start selling business outcomes to industry. Faster consumer broadband was the floor; enterprise and vertical revenue was the upside that justified the spectrum and capex.

The numbers that anchored executive business cases came largely from vendors:

- **5G for industry.** Ericsson's 5G Business Potential work told operators they could add US$204–619 billion (12–36%) to forecast service revenue of US$1.7 trillion in 2026. It set this against forecast core service revenue growth of under 2% a year — 5G was positioned as the escape route.
- **Biggest opportunities.** Ericsson's two largest categories were real-time automation, such as factory and process control, at US$101 billion by 2026, and enhanced video services at US$96 billion. Both were drawn from more than 400 use cases across 10 industries.
- **Private networks.** A 2019 Harvard sizing commissioned by Nokia counted nearly 15 million potential venues for private LTE and 5G.
- **Capabilities on the roadmap.** Network slicing, URLLC, massive IoT and mobile edge computing were presented as near-term products, not as features waiting for a standalone core, devices and an operating model.

Two caveats were in the small print and rarely made it into the investment case. The headline figure was an addressable opportunity, not a forecast, and only part of it was addressable by operators at all — up to 47%, by Ericsson's own estimate. And the top of the range assumed operators would become "service enablers and creators", a business-model change far larger than a network upgrade. That change needed new investment in platforms, skills and partnerships at the very moment industry economics were pushing operators the other way, towards capex reduction and cost-efficiency programmes. Few operators could fund both.

## 2. What actually happened

Operators spent at record pace and the top line did not move. Capital intensity hit an all-time high of 18% in Q3 2022 while service revenue fell, prompting MTN Consulting to conclude that 5G had not delivered the new revenue telcos and investors expected. PwC estimated operators would spend US$275 billion on 5G in 2020–2026 for a return of under 3% on that capital.

| Promise | Outcome by 2026 |
|---|---|
| **5G will lift operator revenue growth** | 5G has nearly 3 billion connections, yet mobile revenue growth has been sluggish, often barely matching inflation (GSMA via EE Times) |
| **5G will deliver advanced capabilities** | Only about 20% of 5G operators have a standalone core (GSMA); 22% by STL Partners' count in January 2026 |
| **Consumers will pay more for 5G** | Most operators could not raise ARPU; 4G proved good enough for most use (Tefficient via Light Reading) |

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| Promise | Outcome by 2026 |
|---|---|
| **Private networks will reach millions of sites** | Fewer than 2,000 private network customer references worldwide at end-2025, against nearly 15 million venues sized (GSA via Mobile Europe) |
| **Private networks will be a profit pool** | Nokia, with about half the world's private networks, lost €100 million on €900 million of revenue in that business (Mobile Europe) |
| **Slicing will sell as a premium product** | Flagship US public-safety slices launched at no extra cost or at existing plan prices (SDxCentral, Light Reading) |

The balance sheet absorbed the gap. The largest wireless operators outside China carried US$1.2 trillion of debt at end-2022, up from US$1.1 trillion four years earlier, with spectrum for 5G accelerating the borrowing (Moody's via WSJ).

Value did land, but not where the business case pointed. Fixed wireless access became the clearest new revenue line: Reliance Jio reached more than 7 million AirFiber subscribers on a dedicated SA slice, and T-Mobile US built a multi-million FWA base. Capacity got cheaper per gigabyte. And in China, operators turned 5G-Advanced into tiered consumer plans priced on experience rather than volume. Even advocates now concede that SA pays back mainly through network efficiency over time, not new revenue.

## 3. Why the revenue did not come

The failure was not technical. The radio works and the standalone core works. The revenue gap came from nine decisions and assumptions, most of them made in executive committees and standards meetings rather than in the network.

1. **Opportunity was mistaken for forecast.** Vendor studies estimated what 5G could be worth across entire industries, then assumed operators would capture a share of it. Analysts later stressed that a market opportunity is not a forecast; market research firm Dell'Oro Group expected private wireless to reach only about 10% of its potential by 2027.
2. **Coverage came before capability.** Non-standalone 5G put new radio on a 4G core, so the features that carried the enterprise case — slicing, URLLC, policy control — waited for SA. Five migration options were standardised and only two deployed. Seven years after launch, roughly four in five 5G operators still lack SA.
3. **Devices and ecosystem lagged the network.** Verizon held back commercial slicing until enough SA-capable devices were on the market, and even now only those devices can use its slices. A capability that only some handsets can use is hard to sell as an SLA. Massive IoT faced a longer wait still: it depends on sensors built into street furniture, meters and industrial equipment, which are replaced every 5–10 years, not every 2–3 years like a smartphone.
4. **Consumer demand had plateaued.** 4G was already good enough for the dominant workload, video. There are only so many hours of video a person will watch on a phone (Access Partnership via Light Reading), and a faster network does not make them watch it faster: a one-hour show still takes an hour. Once a stream plays smoothly, extra speed adds nothing the customer can see. Faster did not mean more valuable.

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5. **Enterprise demand was fragmented and telcos lacked the channel.** Private 5G turned out to be multiple niches, each vertical with its own buyers, integrators and devices. Operators expected to lead that market and found they lacked the vertical expertise.
6. **Competition gave the differentiation away.** Where SA did enable a sellable feature, rivals used it to win share rather than raise price — public-safety slices are the clearest case.
7. **IT and operating model were not ready.** Selling dynamic, SLA-backed connectivity needs catalogue, ordering, charging and assurance that most BSS/OSS stacks could not support; SA monetisation and BSS modernisation are not sequential decisions. Without a modern BSS, operators stay locked into connectivity-based charging — per gigabyte, per line — with no way to price a guaranteed outcome. This is the least visible cause and, in my experience, among the most binding.
8. **Speed league tables punished the move to SA.** In South Korea, the first country to launch 5G, the ICT ministry publishes quality evaluations that rank carriers by measured speed — in the first round, SK Telecom led at 789 Mbps ahead of KT and LGU+. Early SA devices did not support carrier aggregation at the same level as LTE-anchored NSA, so switching to SA meant lower download speeds and a worse ranking. No operator could afford to lose share for a technology claim, and Korean carriers stayed on NSA even with SA cores built and waiting. When the market measures one number, the network is optimised for that number, not for what can be sold.
9. **The standards process runs on a clock built for another era.** A mobile generation still takes about a decade from vision to launch, while AI and software platforms change in weeks. In my experience, standards work also naturally gravitates towards new capabilities: that is what the process exists to produce, and it is where its experts add the most. Operability, cost and migration effort get less attention, so architecture choices are sometimes made without full sight of their long-term operating consequences; five 5G migration options standardised and only two deployed is one example. The specifications have grown so large that vendors choose which features to build; 3GPP's own documents note vendors are largely free to select the features they implement, and several network vendors told me first-hand, during my time on the ATIS board, that they implement only 10–20% of what is specified. That is a lot of features and functionality that go through a long, drawn-out standardisation process and never see the light of day.

Underneath all nine is an older pattern. Analyst Shiv Putcha traces it to the 3G era, when operators invested heavily and kept selling connectivity while value shifted to internet platforms. 5G repeated the cycle with better radios.

## 4. Where 5G SA monetisation is working

The operators earning money from 5G SA have one thing in common: they sell a business outcome the customer already understands, and the technology behind it stays in the background.

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| Operator | What they sell | How it is priced | What it proves |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Reliance Jio** | Home broadband (AirFiber) on a dedicated SA slice; 10 live national slices | Standard broadband plans | Slicing earns its keep by protecting capacity for a mass-market product, not as a premium |
| **China Mobile** | Platinum and gold 5G-A consumer tiers; fan and live-stream packages | Tiered plans with guaranteed experience; Try & Buy | Consumers will pay for measurable experience if it is tracked and defended |
| **T-Mobile US** | SuperMobile business plan: slice + security + satellite | Premium plan tier | Slicing sells as one ingredient of a bundle, not on its own |
| **T-Mobile US and Verizon** | Public-safety slices (T-Priority, Frontline) | No premium | A clear use case drives share gain, not price |
| **Deutsche Telekom** | 5G Live Video Production for broadcasters | Commercial B2B service | Narrow, high-value B2B niches buy assured uplink |
| **Deutsche Telekom, Telefónica, Vodafone, Elisa** | Network APIs such as Quality on Demand, device location and fraud checks | Per call, session or use | The developer route to differentiated connectivity is live but early |

The pattern matters for 6G. None of these succeeded because a new capability existed. Each succeeded because the operator found a buyer with a concrete problem, packaged the answer in a form that buyer already purchases, and either priced it as an outcome or bundled it to win share.

## 5. China: the exception that proves the rule

China is the one large market where 5G clearly lifted operator revenue, at least for a while. Telecom service revenue grew about 1%, 4% and 8% in the first three years of commercial 5G, and all three operators reported higher consumer ARPU in 2022 (Developing Telecoms). The difference was less about technology than about how the market was organised.

1. **The state replaced the business case.** 5G was treated as national infrastructure. In March 2020, the industry ministry (MIIT) told operators to expand standalone 5G coverage and capacity despite the pandemic. By end-2025 China had nearly 5 million 5G base stations, 34 per 10,000 people. State-owned operators built to national targets, not to a payback period.
2. **Standalone from the start.** All three operators chose SA early, avoiding the NSA-to-SA rebuild that stalled other markets (Developing Telecoms). The capabilities needed to sell differentiated service were in the network from the beginning.
3. **Shared build kept costs down.** China Telecom and China Unicom built one shared 5G network, saving more than CNY 270 billion, and operators were sharing over 1.5 million

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base stations by 2023 (Developing Telecoms). Rivals did not compete on coverage claims.

4. **Policy created the enterprise demand.** The government's "5G + industrial internet" programme had more than 17,000 projects across 41 industrial sectors by early 2025, with a target of 10,000 5G factories by 2027. State-owned enterprises acted as anchor customers, which no Western operator could count on.
5. **Operators sold experience, not speed.** Tiered 5G-A plans guarantee a measurable experience gap over ordinary 5G and are defended with continuous monitoring (section 4).

China also turned pilots into deployments. Since 2018, MIIT's "Blooming Cup" contest has asked operators, vendors, industrial companies and universities to solve specific industry problems, then moved winning projects into pilots with industry partners. Over time the scorecard shifted from potential to proof: in 2020 its commercial points rewarded market potential (3rd edition rules); by 2025 they rewarded demonstrated economic benefits and deployment at scale (8th edition rules). The share of projects reaching commercial use rose from 31% in the third edition (Xinhua Daily) to nearly half of about 12,000 in the fourth (China Securities Journal). The contest started from the business need, not the network capability.

Even in China, the lift is fading. Telecom revenue grew less than 1% in 2025 (MIIT via APP), and China Mobile's communications services revenue fell 6% in the first half of 2026, with growth now coming from cloud, computing and AI (TelecomLead).

Most of China's advantages — state direction, coordinated build targets and state-owned anchor customers — cannot be copied elsewhere. Four can: standalone from day one, shared infrastructure where it does not differentiate, anchor customers secured before the build, and pricing on experience rather than speed. And China's own trajectory confirms the paper's central point: connectivity alone does not sustain growth for long.

## 6. The 6G debate today

6G is now on a fixed clock, and operators are shaping it earlier and harder than they did 5G. At its June 2026 plenary in Singapore, 3GPP agreed that Release 21 will carry the first 6G specifications, with a first functional freeze in March 2027 and completion in early 2029. Ericsson expects first commercial systems in 2030.

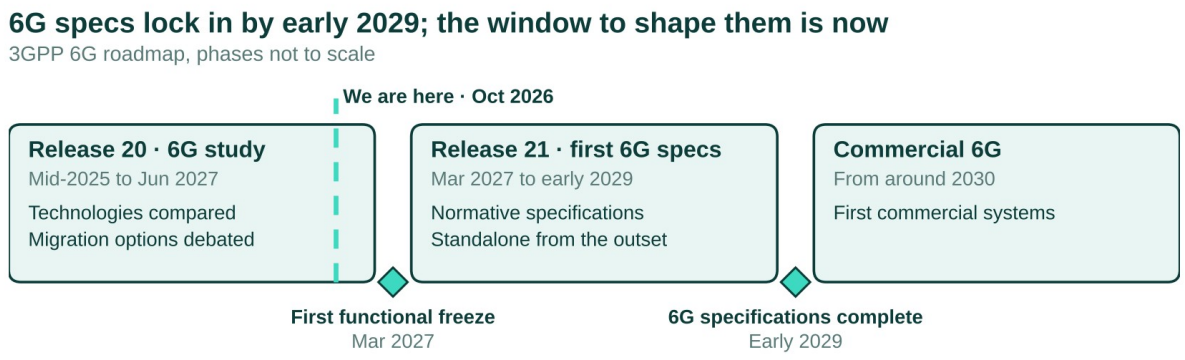



*Figure 1. 3GPP 6G roadmap. Sources: 3GPP via Light Reading; Ericsson.*

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The architectural choices that decide 6G's cost and commercial flexibility are being made before the March 2027 functional freeze — mere months, not years, from now.

**What operators are demanding.** The operator agenda is overwhelmingly about cost and complexity:

- **Standalone from day one.** In submissions to the 3GPP 6G workshop, 30 operators asked for SA from the start and fewer deployment options, and preferred evolving the 5G core over building a new one. 3GPP has since confirmed 6G will be standalone from the outset.
- **Voice from day one.** Operators also asked for native voice support at launch. In 5G, voice was an afterthought: early standalone networks handed calls back to 4G (EPS Fallback) until voice over new radio (VoNR) arrived.
- **No forced hardware refresh.** NGMN's position is that 6G must not inherently trigger a 5G RAN hardware refresh, and that some 6G features should arrive as software upgrades. In September 2026 it backed multi-RAT spectrum sharing as the migration baseline, to be judged on hardware impact, total cost of ownership and commercial viability.
- **Decoupled cycles.** NGMN chair and Orange CTO Laurent Leboucher has called for moving beyond hardware/software "G" cycles towards value-led hardware investment and faster software-led innovation.
- **Migration still open.** The 5G-anchored option that resembles NSA drew the least support, and one analyst warned that getting the choice wrong means a multi-billion-dollar flop.

**What is being promised.** On the revenue side, the vocabulary has changed but the shape of the pitch is familiar. Ericsson expects 6G monetisation to include integrated sensing, distributed computing, AI, positioning and outcome-based offers, with machines becoming customers of the network and network APIs as the bridge. Swisscom's Philipp Bichsel has warned that operators who do not develop the market for SA and slicing now will be disappointed again after 6G launches.

**The early warning signs.** The industry has clearly learned 5G's cost lessons: SA-only, fewer options, software upgrades and hardware reuse are now mainstream operator positions. The revenue lessons are less visible. The monetisation narrative is again led by capability lists — sensing, AI-native, non-terrestrial access — rather than by named buyers, prices and channels. That is the gap executive teams should close before they commit.

**The logo race.** The biggest risk to 6G economics is not a standards decision; it is a marketing one. The pace of 6G will be set by the first large operator in each market that ignores 5G's revenue lessons and sells the logo and its headline capabilities rather than the value customers can draw from them. Once one does, its rivals will follow to avoid losing share, and the whole market will repeat 5G's race to the bottom.

5G shows how quickly this happens. In Korea, KT and LGU+ advertised 5G as 20 times faster than LTE; the government's own measurement found it about four times faster, and subscribers complained of lower-than-expected speeds. Korean operators did report an early ARPU uplift, mainly by moving customers onto pricier 5G plans. That was a repricing of consumer connectivity, not the new enterprise revenue 5G had promised, and once rivals advertised the headline, no one could afford to stay silent. This is a classic prisoner's

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dilemma: each operator is better off if all sell value, but none can afford to be the only one not selling the logo.

## 7. Lessons for 6G, and the questions to ask

Every lesson below follows from one rule: define the business need and establish its value before investing in, or marketing, the capability that serves it. Each maps to a 5G root cause and comes with the questions to answer before committing. The executive leadership team makes the decision, so it should hold every 6G proposal to these questions; a well-advised board will expect them answered before it sanctions that decision. A proposal that cannot answer them is a technology plan, not a business case.

> The first question underpins all the others: **what business need does this meet, and how have we validated what it is worth to the customer?**

1. **Fund outcomes, not generations.** 5G was approved as a generation and justified by use cases afterwards. For 6G, approve capital against specific propositions with named buyer segments, and let the radio follow. NGMN's call to decouple hardware and software cycles is the network-side version of the same principle. **Ask:** Which 6G propositions are we funding, at what price point, and who are the first three reference customers for each? And what did 5G actually return against its original business case, line by line?
2. **Make the network sellable from day one, not just available.** 5G was rolled out coverage first. The radio went up quickly on the old 4G core, and the parts needed to sell anything new — the standalone core, slicing, and the ordering and billing systems — came years later, if at all. For 6G, plan the rollout the other way round: start where there are paying customers, and launch the core, the network features and the IT systems needed to sell to them at the same time as the radio. A capability that cannot be ordered, delivered and billed on day one earns nothing on day one. **Ask:** Will charging, catalogue, ordering and assurance support the first propositions at launch, not a release later?
3. **Sell business outcomes, not network capabilities.** Many customers already pay for 5G as a set of capabilities but make little use of them; what they value is the result. Nobody bought a "slice"; they bought home broadband, a stable live broadcast, or priority in an emergency. 6G sensing, positioning and AI features should be specified as outcomes with service levels and price points before they are specified as features — echoing STL's advice to price on KPI targets rather than API calls. **Ask:** For each proposition, what outcome is the customer buying, at what service level and at what price?
4. **Win through partners where demand is fragmented.** Enterprise 5G proved to be many niches, and with capital under pressure few operators can afford to become service creators themselves. Operators that reach those niches through system integrators, platforms and API aggregators — the model behind GSMA Open Gateway and Aduna — will reach scale faster than those building vertical sales forces from scratch. Three examples show the model. T-Mobile launched its T-Priority public-safety slice with Motorola Solutions, Ericsson and 3rd-Eye Technologies; Motorola Solutions already sells to police and fire departments. Elisa makes Quality on Demand available to developers through Nokia's Network as Code platform, and proved it with remote-driving

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company Elmo. And Aduna, a joint venture of major operators with Ericsson, sells network APIs from AT&T, T-Mobile, Verizon and others through one commercial channel, so a bank can buy fraud checks across several networks in one deal. In each case the operator supplies the capability and the partner brings the customer relationship. **Ask:** Which integrators, platforms or API aggregators take it to market, and what revenue share will they take?

5. **Build your own business case, and tie spending to revenue, not rollout.** A vendor's market size describes what a whole market might be worth, not what one operator will earn. Use it to decide where to look, never as revenue in the business case, and build the case bottom-up, one proposition at a time. Network capital is always phased over several years, but the phases are usually tied to rollout milestones — sites built, coverage reached. Tie spending on new services to commercial milestones instead — signed customers, a revenue run-rate — and report realised revenue against the original case at each one. **Ask:** Where did the market sizing come from, and which commercial milestones release the next tranche of spending on new services? What happens if they are missed?
6. **Build the market before the network.** The 6G buyers will largely be developed on 5G SA and 5G-Advanced between now and 2030. Operators that cannot sell differentiated connectivity on today's network will not suddenly sell it on 6G — Bichsel's warning is the right one. **Ask:** What differentiated connectivity revenue are we already earning on 5G SA today?
7. **Count efficiency as a legitimate return, and say so.** Much of 5G's real payback came through cost per gigabyte, energy and automation. A 6G case that is honest about efficiency as the base return, with new revenue as a gated upside, is more credible to investors than another revenue promise. **Ask:** How much of the case is efficiency, and how much is new revenue? Show them separately, with the new revenue gated.
8. **Decouple innovation from the standards clock.** If vendors build only a fraction of each release, operators should name the fraction that matters to their propositions and hold vendors to it — much as operators once defined a short list of essential features for 3G. Operators should also bring operations and cost expertise into standards work alongside their technology experts, so each new capability is weighed against what it will cost to deploy and run, as NGMN now does in judging 6G migration options on hardware impact and total cost of ownership. Everything that can move at software speed — AI, automation, network APIs — should be delivered through open interfaces and cloud-native platforms on a commercial roadmap, not wait for the next G. **Ask:** Which 6G features will our vendors actually ship, and when? And what hardware does 6G force us to replace, separate from refresh we would do anyway for end-of-life or energy?
9. **Refuse the logo race, and plan for a rival who won't.** Agree internally that 6G will be marketed only on a sellable outcome, never on the logo or a peak speed. Work through industry bodies and with regulators to shift published quality rankings from peak speed towards experience, reliability and capability, so the metric stops punishing the right architecture. And pre-plan the response if a competitor launches on the logo: match the claim at minimal cost, keep capital on the propositions that earn. **Ask:** What will we do if a competitor markets the logo first, and which published rankings could penalise the architecture we want?

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A final point on credibility. Executive teams that committed to 5G on vendor numbers now face boards and investors who are entitled to scepticism. Teams that pre-empt it with a smaller, evidenced case will find capital, and board sanction, easier to secure than those who repeat the 2018 pitch with a new number.

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